

AL SURUR

The Warehouse Storage Buying Guide

How to choose the right racking, shelving and mezzanine solution for your facility

Al Surur General Store Equipment Trading LLC · Ajman, UAE · 18+ Years, 500+ Projects

1. Choosing the Right System for Your Load

The biggest mistake facilities make is picking a racking type based on price alone, without matching it to how goods actually move. Here's a quick guide:

System	Best For	Key Benefit
Selective Pallet Racking	Wide product range, frequent picking	Direct access to every pallet
Drive-In Racking	High volume of a few SKUs	Maximum density, less aisle space
Cantilever Racking	Long items — pipes, timber, profiles	No vertical obstruction
Mezzanine Floors	Limited floor area, high ceiling	Doubles usable space without expansion
Longspan Shelving	Cartons, bins, irregular items	Flexible shelf heights

Quick rule of thumb

If you pick from more than 20% of your SKUs on a typical day → Selective Racking.

If 80%+ of your movement is on a handful of fast-moving items → Drive-In Racking.

If your ceiling height is more than double what you're using → Mezzanine Floor is almost always worth it.

2. Calculating Your Storage Capacity

Before requesting a quote, having rough numbers ready speeds everything up:

- **Floor area** available for racking (length x width, in meters)
- **Clear height** to the lowest ceiling obstruction (sprinklers, beams, lights)
- **Pallet/item dimensions** and typical weight per unit
- **Forklift type** — determines minimum aisle width (counterbalance forklifts need wider aisles than reach trucks)

Simple formula: Usable storage positions $\approx$ (Floor Area $\div$ Bay Footprint) $\times$ Levels per Bay

A typical selective racking bay with 3 levels on a standard pallet footprint gives roughly 3x the ground-floor storage of open floor stacking — this is why racking pays for itself quickly once volume grows.

3. Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Ignoring load ratings.** Every beam and upright has a rated capacity — overloading is a genuine safety hazard, not just a compliance issue.
- **Underestimating aisle width.** Racking that looks efficient on paper can make your forklift unusable if aisles are too tight for its turning radius.
- **Skipping the site survey.** Floor levelness, ceiling obstructions and column placement all affect what actually fits — a photo or rough sketch isn't enough for an accurate quote.
- **Buying for today only.** If you're growing, ask about expandable/modular racking systems that let you add bays later without replacing everything.
- **Forgetting fire code clearance.** UAE Civil Defense requires minimum clearances around sprinklers and exits — factor this in before finalizing layout.

4. What to Ask Any Supplier Before You Buy

- Do you handle design, fabrication AND installation, or just one of these?
- What's your typical lead time from order to installation?
- Is the racking load-rated and can you provide the rating certificate?
- Do you offer a free site survey before quoting?
- What happens if I need to expand later — is the system modular?
- What's included in the warranty, and for how long?

Pre-Quote Checklist

- ☐ Floor area measured (length x width)
- ☐ Clear ceiling height measured
- ☐ Typical item/pallet size & weight noted
- ☐ Forklift type confirmed
- ☐ Growth plan for next 2-3 years considered
- ☐ Photos or a rough sketch of the space ready to share

Ready for an accurate quote?

Al Surur offers a completely free site survey — our engineers visit, take exact measurements, and give you a precise quote, no obligation.

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